Canada Water Agency | Agence de l'eau du Canada

Community-Based Water Quality Monitoring in the Upper Great Lakes

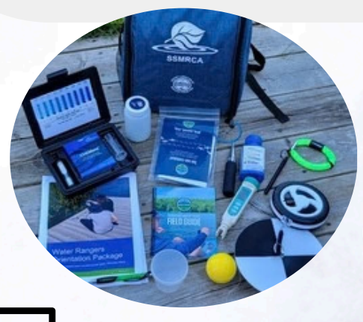
Sault Ste. Marie Region Conservation Authority — SSMRCA

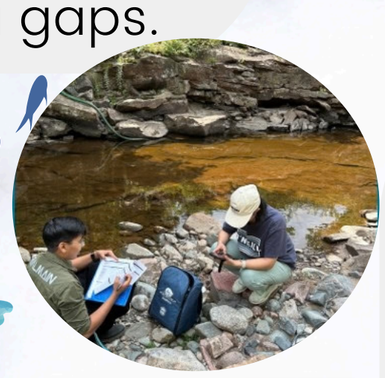
Building local knowledge and capacity to understand and protect our waters

About the project

Communities lead, we support, waters win

We support community-led water quality monitoring from lower Lake Superior to Lake Huron's North Shore. Communities gain capacity to protect local waterways, expand community-based science, and address local priorities & data gaps.





How we engage

Awareness, training, place-making, action

- Identify sites, what to monitor, community priorities, and needed tools.
- Provide training, monitoring supplies, guidance, access to specialized expertise.
- Develop region-specific methods.
- Increase community cohesion and belonging between water protectors, their communities, and local waterways.
- Build pathways for community-based science to inform decisions.
- Recognize volunteer commitment through certificates, ribbons, and medals.
- Ensure accessible opportunities for all ages and abilities to learn, connect, and have fun.

5-year achievements (2021-2026)

Engagement, data, research, mentoring tomorrow's Northern Ontario water warriors

- **>75,000 social media impressions** improved awareness of water quality.
- **>10,000 people reached** at >40 public events - training, field sampling (chemistry, eDNA, insect surveys), classroom & laboratory sessions, and public outreach.
- **>200 volunteers** monitoring 46 sites collected **>45,000 data points** over 465 site visits.
- **67 youth mentored, trained, and/or hired** (52 Indigenous youth interns & hires from 15 First Nations across Canada + 15 post-secondary student placements).
- **8 communities** benefited from pilot monitoring programs and capacity development, 4 of which now independently manage their own permanent, expanded programs.
- **2 public campaigns** - microplastics & road salts (Ste. Marys River) - completed
- **2 community-driven special projects** - nutrients & E. coli (lower Lake Superior and Lake Huron's North Shore) - initiated (completion by March 2027).

FOLLOW US ON

OR

Northern Ontario Research, Development, Ideas and Knowledge
NORDIK INSTITUTE

Shaping Outreach, Understanding, Research and Community Engagement with Water